

THE POWER OF CREATIVITY AT WORK

Skills, teamwork, and what it takes to build a successful business • WEEK 6 • LEVEL A

Yesterday, we looked at how the world of employment is changing — from remote work and flexible hours to the rise of self-employment and entrepreneurship. Today, we go deeper into what actually makes people successful in the workplace. It is not just about having the right qualifications or working hard. The skills that employers value most in the modern world include **creativity**, **teamwork**, **problem-solving**, and the ability to communicate well with others. These are sometimes called 'soft skills' — and they can make the difference between a good worker and a great one.

Think about the last time you had to solve a difficult problem — perhaps at school, at home, or in a group project. Did you **brainstorm** ideas with others? Did you take the **initiative** and lead the group, or did you prefer to support someone else's plan? Did you ask for **feedback** and use it to improve? All of these behaviours are directly relevant to the workplace — and developing them now will give you a huge advantage later in your career.

How do you approach challenges at work or school? Consider these situations:

1 Your team has a difficult project to complete and nobody is sure where to start. What do you do?

a I wait for someone else to take the lead — I do not want to make the wrong decision.

b I suggest we brainstorm ideas together and divide the tasks based on everyone's strengths.

2 You receive critical feedback on your work from your manager. How do you react?

a I feel upset and find it hard not to take it personally — I worked very hard on this.

b I listen carefully, ask questions to understand what needs to improve, and use it positively.

If you answered b) to both questions, you already have some of the most important qualities employers look for. People who take **initiative**, use **feedback** constructively, and collaborate well with their teams are far more likely to thrive in a modern workplace — and far more likely to be considered for promotion.

■ STRONG WORKPLACE HABITS

- Takes **initiative** without always waiting to be told what to do.
- Gives and receives **feedback** in a constructive and professional way.
- Manages time well and meets deadlines without constant reminders.
- Can **mentor** junior colleagues and share knowledge generously.
- Negotiates calmly and finds **compromise** when conflicts arise.
- Brings fresh ideas and is not afraid to challenge the **strategy**.

■■ HABITS TO WORK ON

- Waits passively for instructions rather than showing **initiative**.
- Reacts defensively to **feedback** and struggles to accept criticism.
- Struggles with **time management** and often misses deadlines.
- Keeps knowledge to themselves rather than helping others to grow.
- Avoids difficult conversations and lets conflicts fester unresolved.
- Sticks rigidly to existing ideas and resists new approaches or change.

85%

of job success comes from soft skills, not technical ones

3x

more creative output in teams that feel psychologically safe

92%

of employees say a good mentor changes their career

70%

of projects fail due to poor communication in the team

Why Creativity Matters in Business

Creativity is not just for artists, designers, or writers. In the business world, creativity means finding new and better ways to solve problems, improve products, or reach customers. A company that stops being creative quickly falls behind its competitors. Think about some of the world's most successful brands — Apple, Nike, Netflix — and you will notice that what made them different was not just a good product, but a completely new way of thinking about what people needed.

One of the most common ways to generate creative ideas in a team is through brainstorming — a session where everyone is encouraged to share their thoughts freely, without judgement. The goal is quantity over quality at first: the more ideas you generate, the more likely you are to find a great one. After the **brainstorm**, the team can discuss, refine, and develop the best ideas further. Many successful products and campaigns began as a rough idea on a whiteboard that someone was brave enough to share.

Teamwork, Conflict, and Communication

Good **teamwork** requires more than just getting along with people. It means being able to **delegate** tasks effectively — trusting others to do their part rather than trying to do everything yourself. It means being an active listener, giving clear and respectful **feedback**, and being open to other people's ideas even when they are different from your own. And it means being able to handle **conflict** when it arises — because in any team, disagreements are inevitable.

When **conflict** happens at work, the most effective approach is usually to **negotiate** calmly and look for a **compromise** — a solution that both sides can accept, even if neither gets exactly what they wanted. Avoiding conflict entirely rarely works; it tends to make problems worse over time. A workplace that values **diversity** — different backgrounds, perspectives, and experiences — and works hard to be **inclusive** tends to have fewer unresolved conflicts and much higher levels of innovation.

"Alone we can do so little. Together we can do so much."

— Helen Keller

From Idea to Business: How It Actually Works

Many people dream of starting their own business — but the reality requires careful planning and strong organisational skills. Before you can **launch** a product or service, you need a clear **strategy**: who is your **target** customer, what problem are you solving, and how will you make a **profit**? You also need to think about **investment** — the money you will need to get started — and how long it might take before the business stops making a **loss** and starts to earn money.

Many businesses begin with a **prototype** — an early version of a product that can be tested and improved before the final version is produced. This allows the team to identify problems early, gather **feedback** from real users, and make changes before spending large amounts of money on full production. Building a strong **brand** — a clear identity and set of values that customers recognise and trust — is also essential for long-term success.

Time management is critical throughout this process. Entrepreneurs and business leaders often have to **multitask** — managing several things at once — and the risk of **burnout** is real. Learning when to **delegate**, when to ask for help, and when to stop working is just as important as knowing how to work hard. The most successful business leaders are not necessarily the ones who work the most hours — they are the ones who use their time most wisely.

Finding a Mentor — and Becoming One

One of the most powerful things you can do for your career is to find a **mentor** — someone with more experience who is willing to share their knowledge, give honest **feedback**, and help you grow. A good mentor does not do the work for you — they ask the right questions, challenge your thinking, and help you see possibilities you might have missed on your own. Many successful business leaders credit a mentor with transforming their career.

And as you gain experience yourself, you will have the opportunity to **mentor** others in return. Sharing your knowledge, supporting someone who is just starting out, and helping to build an **inclusive** workplace where everyone has the chance to develop — these are among the most rewarding things you can do in any career. The best workplaces are those where people genuinely help each other to grow.

ACTIVITIES

3

Read the article and answer True (T) or False (F).

- 1 Soft skills are less important than technical qualifications in most jobs.
- 2 Brainstorming works best when people only share their most polished ideas.
- 3 Conflict in the workplace should always be avoided.
- 4 A prototype is an early version of a product used for testing and improvement.
- 5 Diversity and inclusion can help teams become more innovative.
- 6 A mentor does the work for you and tells you what decisions to make.

4

Match the highlighted words in the article to their meanings.

- 1 to generate many ideas freely in a group, without immediate judgement
- 2 a middle point that both sides can accept after a disagreement
- 3 to give tasks or responsibilities to other people in your team
- 4 a first working version of a product, made before the final design
- 5 an experienced person who guides and supports someone less experienced
- 6 a state of physical and mental exhaustion caused by overworking

5

Read the article again and answer these questions in full sentences.

- 1 Why does the article say that creativity is important for all businesses, not just creative ones?
- 2 What does effective teamwork require, according to the article?
- 3 What is a business strategy, and what questions should it answer?
- 4 Why is a mentor valuable — and what does a good mentor do?

6

Think of a business idea you would like to start. Write 5–7 sentences describing it.

Use these phrases to help you:

My business idea is ... / My target customer is ... / I would need to invest ... / One challenge would be ... / I would build a brand that ...

■ TALKING POINTS

Do you think creativity can be taught — or is it something you are born with?

Have you ever had a mentor or role model at school or in your life? How did they help you?

What do you think is the biggest challenge of working in a team? How would you deal with it?

Would you rather lead a team or be a strong team member? What are the advantages of each?